

William Cobbett, Thomas Paine & Fleet Street

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William Cobbett (1763-1835) was a brilliant journalist, author and public speaker who, late in life, became M.P. for Oldham. The son of a Farnham tavern keeper, he started out as a farm labourer and gardener before enlisting in the army.

As a young man he was extremely conservative in his political beliefs, beginning his career as a journalist by opposing the French Revolution and its supporters (including Thomas Paine) under the pseudonyms Humfrey Hedgehog and Peter Porcupine. But in 1803 he was converted to radical reform by reading Paine's *Decline and Fall of the English System of Finance*, an objection to the government's funding system because it seemed to transfer wealth from the poor to the rich, while threatening to bankrupt the nation. Thereafter, Cobbett became a constant scourge of the political establishment. Declaring himself 'the poor man's friend', he adopted as his symbol the gridiron, signifying his determination to give corruption and its practitioners a severe roasting.

Thomas Paine had died abroad in 1809 and was buried on his farm in New York State. In gratitude to him, Cobbett decided, ten years later, to repatriate his remains and give them a fitting funeral in Paine's birthplace, the Norfolk town of Thetford. However, when Cobbett reached England with the bones in November 1819, he faced fierce criticism from conservatives and radical reformers alike. For them Paine was not, as Cobbett claimed, a great patriot but a monstrous enemy of church and state because of his anti-Christianity and hostility to hereditary government. Realising his mistake, Cobbett decided to let matters lie. Rather than disposing of the bones, he retained them for the rest of his life, mainly stored in shops he rented in Fleet Street for printing and selling his works. Throughout the 1820s the bones were kept at 183 Fleet Street in Johnsons Court and, in the early 1830s, moved to 11 Bolt Court. In 1833 they were taken to a farm in Surrey where Cobbett lived with them until his death in 1835.



Paine's posthumous connection with Fleet Street also lay in the fact that Cobbett's first storage address for the bones was a shop formerly rented by William Sherwin (1800–1848), a bold youth who was as infatuated as Cobbett with Paine, but for different reasons. In the window of Sherwin's shop a notice declared it to be 'The Republican Office', from which Sherwin published, from March 1817, a weekly journal initially called the *Republican* and then Sherwin's *Political Register* (1817–19). Yet his main mission was to republish Paine's political writings which, for fear of prosecution, no one had attempted for twenty-two years. This he fulfilled by October 1818.

In the dangerous work of republishing Paine, Sherwin was joined in 1817 by Richard Carlile (1790–1843), a tinsmith. Carlile's aim was to reprint Paine's theological works, notably *The Age of Reason*, which dismissed the Bible as fiction, completed by December 1818.

When Sherwin gave up his shop at 183 Fleet Street, Carlile established a bookshop and printing office at 55 Fleet Street. For selling *The Age of Reason* he was convicted of blasphemy and sentenced to six years (1819–25) in Dorchester Gaol. Terrified of a similar fate, the newly married Sherwin ended his connection with Paineite radicalism.

Despite his imprisonment, Carlile continued the publication and sale of Paine's works through Fleet Street shops at 55, 84, 135 and 62 Fleet Street, aided by his wife, sister and several shop assistants, many of whom were also imprisoned. He also produced a weekly journal entitled the *Republican* that, for six years (1819–26), maintained a network of Paine Societies throughout the country.

During this time Paine's bones lay a stone's throw away on the other side of Fleet Street, but Carlile would have nothing to do with them or with Cobbett, preferring to read Paine's works rather than worship his remains. After his release from prison in 1825, Carlile established another shop at 62 Fleet Street, calling it his *Temple of Reason*. From there he upheld the cause for a further ten years before retiring to Enfield where, in the year of Cobbett's death and with failing health, he gave up the struggle to found a Paineite republic.